

EPISODE ONE

The premise, in a few paragraphs

Working title not settled. For Stephen and Trish to read and amend before anything else is built on it.

A woman is murdered in her own home. It is recorded as an accident, so nobody investigates, and within a few weeks it is simply a sad thing that happened to somebody.

She had four close friends. In the months before she died she had become frightened, because she had worked out that one of those four was planning to kill her. She hid what she had. She did not go to the police, partly because what she had was not quite proof, and mostly because taking it to them meant accusing somebody she loved. So she made an arrangement instead. If anything happened to her, all four of them would be sent a key.

After the funeral, the keys arrive. All four of them go to the same place.

It is already empty.

So four people who loved her are left knowing one thing for certain: one of the other three got there first. They have nothing they can take to the police. What they have is each other, and the fact that between them they knew her better than anyone alive did. They start meeting. They start working out which of them it is.

One of them gets close.

A few days later one of the four disappears. His car is found near the coast, his phone is left behind, and no body is ever recovered.

And then, after he is already gone, the friend who had been getting close is murdered.

The story everybody accepts is that somebody outside the group took one of them and later killed another. The two who are left know something the police do not, which is that it was one of the four. And the man who vanished seems to have been taken before the last murder, which appears to put him out of it.

Which leaves two people, each of whom is now certain that the other one did it.

He is alive. Disappearing was not an escape. It was an alibi for a murder he had not yet committed, and he chose which of them to kill because she was the one about to see it.

Ally comes to all of this afterwards. She prevents nothing, and she could not have. What her podcast does is establish that the man everybody has spent two years mourning was never harmed at all.

And that is the thing that puts somebody in danger. He has been safe for one reason only: everyone believes he is dead. There is one person alive who could prove otherwise, somebody in the life he has built since, who knows him under a different name and has no idea who he used to be. He has never managed to find her. But every episode Ally puts out describes him a little more clearly to everybody listening, and he is listening.

She cannot stop without letting the case die. She cannot go on without walking him to the one person who can undo him.

What it is actually about

The woman who died was the best of the four at seeing what was in front of her. The two who survived are the two who were not.

They were spared because they were not good enough, and she died because she was. Neither of them will ever say that out loud to the other, and it sits underneath every conversation they have.

Still open at this stage, so you know what you can change

- **The title.** *Five Keys After Midnight* is retired. Current suggestion is *The Friend They Mourned*.
- **Who the four are.** Not decided at all. Fable writes them next, without being told which one did it, so that all four are written as people any of whom could be.
- **What she actually hid,** and how she came by it.
- **How long ago all of this happened,** and what brings Ally to it now.
- **Which of the two survivors comes to her,** and why that one.
- **Where in Havenbay it sits,** including the coast where his car is found.
- Whether the friend who is murdered second is a woman, as written here.

What is settled and would be expensive to move: four friends rather than five · the death recorded as an accident · the cupboard already empty when they get there · him vanishing before the second murder rather than after · Ally arriving after all of it.